What is an Epic?

An Epic is a strategic body of work that delivers value in the form of a new product, product capability, or outcome.

Epics correlate to an initiative's business outcomes and contribute to the parent objective's success metric and key result achievement.

Epics in Aha! represent multiple tactical features that collectively deliver an increment of value.

Here at Mastercard, our products are Epic and answer the Why, How, and Who of value creation.

Mastercard Backlog Structure

Epic Principles

- Product Managers and PM-Ts must use Problem Statements to define and quantify a problem space, ecosystem, desired value/outcomes, and Mastercard benefit.
- Product Managers and PM-Ts must own and manage Epics in Aha to ensure accurate **Objective**, **Initiative,** and **Product** alignment.
    - All Epics in Aha! must map to a Mastercard Catalog Product in the Product field in Aha!

- Epics must align with a Program Objective Success Metric and the Epic's description in Aha! must convey how an Epic's delivery contributes to Program Objective Success Metric achievement.
    - Click **here** to learn more about Program Objective Success Metrics.
- Product Managers and PM-Ts partner with Engineering Managers, TPMs, and Technical SMEs to decompose Epics into features that create incremental value.
    - An Epic's Features must include all functional and non-functional stories needed to deliver the Epic's intended outcome or value.
    - Click **here** to learn more about **KTLO, BAU, and Technical Debt**.
- Product Managers and PM-Ts must partner with Engineering Managers, TPMs, and Technical SMEs to:
    - Estimate an Epic's high-level scope, duration, and LOE (Level of Effort) in T-Shirt sizes.
        - Capture Estimates in the Preliminary Estimate Field in Aha!
    - Identify, negotiate, and sequence an Epic's dependencies,
        - Click **here** to learn more about **Dependencies**.
- Product Managers and PM-Ts must analyze, refine, and prioritize three to six months of epics during a recurring Program Review and Refinement event to ensure a continuous flow of value creation.
    - Click **here** to learn more about **Prioritization**.
- Program Co-Founders, Owners, Product Managers, and PM-Ts must use the **Strategic Alignment & Flow** dashboard to govern Strategy and tactical Alignment, Roadmap Health, and Epic data.

Epic Guidelines

Epic Ideation

Product Managers and PM-Ts partner with Engineering, Delivery leaders, and Technical SMEs to capture an Epic's Description of Work, Value Statement, Assumptions, Definition of Done, and what is Out of Scope to inform refinement and decomposition discussions.

Consider using one of the below methods to inform Epic Descriptions in Aha!

Problem Statement: A synopsis that conveys how a product, service, or outcome meets a customer's or user's needs better than its competitor or previous versions.

Epic Story: Leveraging user story format, draft a story that conveys the Epic requirements on a high level to help Product, Engineering, Delivery Leaders, and Technical SMEs understand the opportunity problem space and ideate potential features.

Click **here** for **Epic Ideation Guidance**.

Capturing Epics in Aha!

Leverage the Epic description field in Aha to capture Epic ideation outcomes,

Technology Program Example

What	Why	How
Description of Work	Epic Story or Statement	The Authorization Platform uses network manag system or network events or tasks. These messa communicate network status conditions. Netwo be customer-initiated or Authorization Platform- Typical uses of customer-initiated network man following: • Sign in to and sign out from the Authoriza • Activate or deactivate socket connection

		• Request network connection status • Perform encryption key management tas Typical uses of system-initiated network manag following: • Request network connection status • Perform encryption key management tas The objective of this epic is to build out the targe Connectivity Status Management application in landscape. Although we will be using the moder to support the current systems and replicate the network management application. The intentior current mainframe network connectivity applica once the new solution is tested and working.
Value Statement	Convey Epic outcome value	**Problem Statement:** **For** <Issuers that need to be signed on to the ne **Who** <Use Authorization Platform for Banknet, N **The** <Network Connectivity Status Management **Is a** <solution> **That** <handles customer or system-initiated Ne messages> **Unlike** <today's mainframe network manageme **Our Solution** < Supports Dual Message Switch. impact due to SISO (sign on sign off) being hand application. Customers will not be asked to sign into the new system. Migration should all happe impacting the customers.>
Assumptions	Provide transparency into the known-unknown Product,	• We will be processing the 0800 network r messages and respond with the 0810 to t

(Coming Soon)	Engineering or Delivery risk that may impede value delivery.	• NCSM app needs to be able to replace th connectivity application so it can be dec • NCSM app needs to listen to broadcasts intermediate phase when both are runni • NCSM app needs to send the sign on sta system's MIPs • There is no need to share sign on status a
Definition of Done	Desired Epic Outcomes	1. NCSM application is live on production f Satellite 2. NCSM application deployed in the Europ connectivity for on-soil Nexus 3. NCSM application deployed in central si (banknet) and be a replacement for mai application 4. Handling of 0800 sign on / off messages 5. Sequence Diagrams and Documentatio 6. Functional logs documentation is availa searchable in dashboard 7. Full test coverage with test results poste 8. Performance testing done 9. Feature Demos completed

Out of Scope	Convey value not being delivered	• Migrate Sign on / off capabilities off mai
		  ○ This epic will focus on building ou mirroring the connectivity statues mainframe application to prepare
		• Sign on for Acquirers
		  ○ Ability to source messages to onli

		▪ Online Clearing Acquirers credentials ▪ Need to know the routes to ▪ Start storing sign on status • System generated echo tests ○ Customers can request the Maste probe via echo test to make sure ○ This is currently not set up in the • Upgrading the SA solution to using this m ○ We want to get to this quickly, but modernized state first with Europe

Estimation

Product Managers and PM-Ts must partner with Engineering Managers, TPMs, and Technical SMEs to explore and analyze Epic requirements to surface the Epic's Preliminary T-Shirt size when Epics are Exploring status.

T-Shirt Size	Iterations/Sprints
S	3-4
M	5-6
L	7-8

Iteration or Sprint = 2 Weeks

Epics that require 8+ Iterations/Sprints must be decomposed into smaller Epics that align with the above T-Shirt Size Guidelines.

Decomposition

Epics are decomposed into tactical features with benefit hypothesis statements and stories that meet INVEST.

Program Leaders must partner to ensure Epic Features' concurrent delivery in at most **16 weeks** during a recurring Refinement Event.

Click **here** for Decomposition guidance.

MVP Definition & Studio's Prototype Phase

What: An MVP (Minimum Viable Product) is a **first version** of a product, service or outcome that has enough features to attract customers, validate expected behaviors, and use customer feedback to inform later versions.

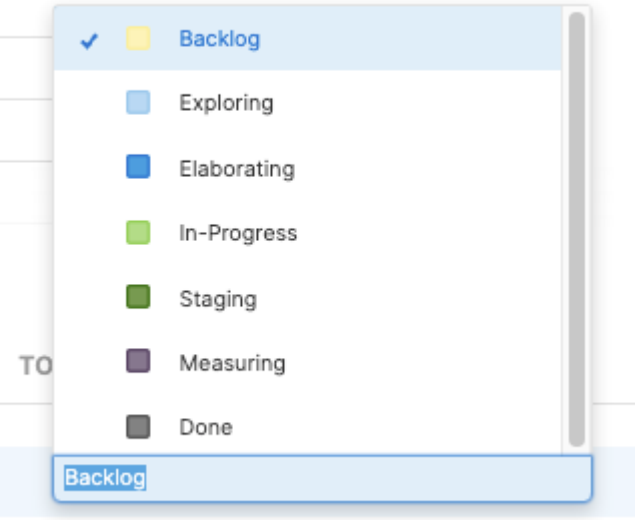
Why: Validate the intended customer experience with customers and distribution partners to surface issues, bugs and other later version enhancements.

How: Identify just enough Epics to satisfy external or internal customer needs and establish an early adopter feedback mechanism to inform subsequent solution versions.

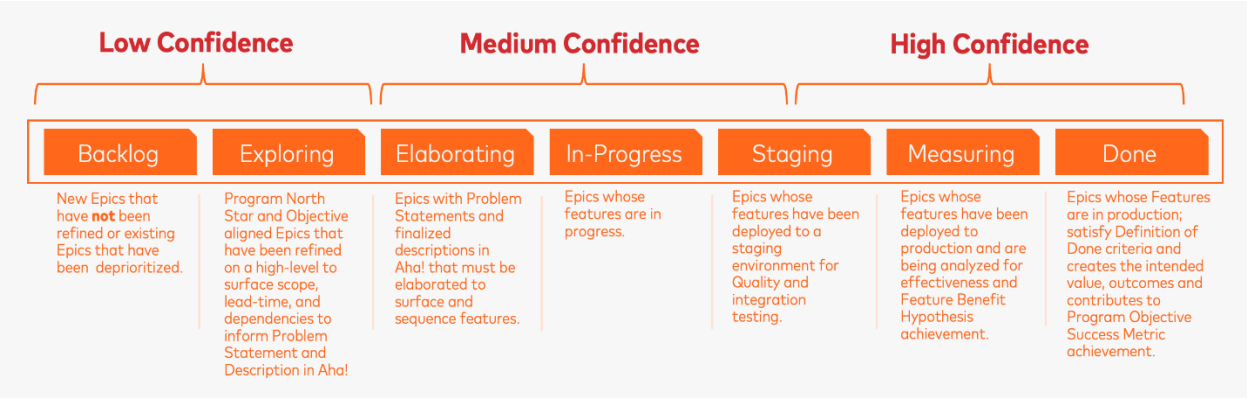
Click **here** for MVP Definition guidance.

Epic Lifecycle, Status Designations & Confidence Intervals

Product Managers and PM-Ts are responsible for ensuring Aha Epic status lifecycle designation accuracy.



Epic Lifecyle Status Designations

Each Epic Status designation maps to our Confidence Intervals

(*Low [12+ Months Out], Medium [6-12 Months Out] and High [Now - 6 Months Out]*)